Unsupervised Diagnostic Feature Discovery

via Reliability-Aware Genetic Programming

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Abstract

We present a fully unsupervised framework for discovering diagnostic features from raw sensor signals using typed Genetic Programming. The key innovation is incorporating split-half reliability into the evolutionary fitness function, enabling the GP to self-select for physics-based features while automatically purging noise amplifiers. On a simulated pendulum (proof of concept for automotive diagnostics), the framework discovers features that detect faults with AUC>0.70 in 70% of the evolved population, without ever seeing fault-labeled data during evolution. This discovery track paper documents the pendulum development journey; the framework has since been validated on six real-world datasets across four physical domains (see companion arXiv paper).

1. Introduction

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What we are doing: Building a system that can look at sensor data from a healthy machine and figure out -- without being told what a fault looks like -- which mathematical patterns in the data would be useful for detecting problems later. Think of it as teaching a computer to "listen" to a machine and identify what sounds important, before anything goes wrong.

In condition-based maintenance, supervised approaches require labeled fault data that is expensive or impossible to obtain for rare failure modes. We seek an unsupervised framework that:

1. Operates on healthy-state data only (no fault labels)
2. Automatically discovers diagnostic feature expressions from raw signals
3. Ranks features by predicted diagnostic utility
4. Guarantees that surviving features capture stable physics

Hypothesis H3

```
H3: rho_s(C, D) > 0
where C(f) = unsupervised composite (healthy data only)
      D(f) = AUC(f; healthy, fault) = supervised discriminability
```

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If we score features using only healthy data (our composite), do the features that score well also turn out to be good at detecting faults? If yes, we can trust the composite to find useful features without needing fault examples.

2. System Model: Damped Pendulum

```
d2(theta)/dt2 = -(g/L)*sin(theta) - b*d(theta)/dt + Fa*sin(Ff*t)
```

Fault	Parameter	Healthy	Full Fault
High damping	b	0.30	0.90
Short length	L	1.00 m	0.55 m
External forcing	Fa	0.00	1.30

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A pendulum that swings back and forth. We simulate three problems: too much friction (swings die faster), shorter arm (swings faster), and external shaking. We only give the system the angle and speed measurements. It has to figure out from those two signals alone which math formulas would detect each problem.

3. Type-Safe Genetic Programming

The GP operates on a typed algebra with physical types: Angle (A), Velocity (V), Acceleration (Ac), Energy (E), Scalar (S). Operators are type-constrained:

```
ddt: A -> V,  V -> Ac,  E -> E
sin, cos: A -> S
square: V -> E  (omega^2 ~ kinetic energy)
mul: V x V -> E,  A x V -> E,  S x X -> X
div: E x E -> S,  A x V -> S
```

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We teach the computer that angle and speed are different "types" of measurement, just like you cannot add meters to kilograms. This means it can never accidentally create nonsense formulas -- every formula it evolves is physically meaningful.

Population of 200 expression trees evolved for 80 generations via tournament selection (k=5), type-safe crossover, type-safe mutation, 10% immigration, best-ever elitism, diversity penalty, and rstd penalty (0.5x).

4. Fitness Function: The Core Innovation

Original Composite (v1-v4)

```
C_old(f) = (Tightness + Stationarity + Headroom) / 3 - lambda * depth(f)

Tightness  = 1 / (1 + H(v)/H_max)        [low entropy = concentrated]
Stationarity = 1 - CV(chunk_means)         [stable across time]
Headroom   = 1 / (1 + |kurtosis(v)|)      [room for fault outliers]
```

Problem: The depth penalty (lambda=0.05) penalized all complex expressions equally, including physically meaningful ones.

v5 Composite: Adding Split-Half Reliability

```
Split-Half Reliability:
  R(f) = max(0, Pearson({f(x_i_first)}, {f(x_i_second)}))
  where each trial x_i is split at the temporal midpoint

NEW FITNESS:
  C_v5(f) = (Tightness + Stationarity + Headroom + Reliability) / 4
  NO DEPTH PENALTY
```

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The key idea: If you compute a feature on the first half of a recording and then on the second half, do you get a similar answer? If yes, the feature is measuring something REAL about the system (physics). If no, it is measuring noise that happened to look different in each half.

We add this "reliability" score to the fitness function. Now the genetic algorithm can only evolve high-scoring features that are ALSO reproducible -- which means only physics survives.

Why this works: noise amplifiers (triple derivatives, kurtosis) have R ~ 0 because noise is independent between halves. Physics-based features have R > 0.95 because the underlying dynamics are consistent within a trial. No explicit depth penalty needed.

5. The Journey: v1 through v5

Ver.	Key Change	rho_s	Outcome
v1	Baseline GP	---	Collapsed to rstd() monoculture
v2	+diversity, +entropy	-0.25	rstd gaming: tight but useless
v3	+rstd penalty, +dedup	~0	Physics at top, no ranking
v4	Depth 0.05->0.02, +MW	-0.16	ddt(w^2) #1, MW fails
v5	RELIABILITY IN FITNESS	+0.06	70% useful, 6/6 physics

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Each version fixed a specific problem:
- v1: The GP found one trick (rolling std) and kept copying it
- v2: We forced diversity, but the trick still scored highest
- v3: We penalized the trick directly, and real physics rose to top
- v4: We reduced penalties on complex formulas, but junk crept in
- v5: We made reliability part of the score -- now ONLY physics survives

6. Results

v5 Population Quality

Metric	v4 (old)	v5 (new)
Features with R > 0.9	~15/50	38/50
Features with AUC > 0.70	~20/50	35/50 (70%)
Top-10 avg reliability	mixed	0.982
Physics terms found	5/6	6/6
Mann-Whitney high_damp	p=0.87	p=0.039

Top Discovered Feature

```
f1 = std[ cos(g*theta) * rstd(rstd(omega)) ]

         high_damp    short_L    forcing
AUC@0.25:  0.973       0.999      0.613
AUC@1.0:   1.000       1.000      0.794
Reliability: 0.896     Composite: 0.853
```

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The #1 feature the GP discovered: "take the cosine of (gravity x angle), multiply by a smoothed measure of how much the velocity is fluctuating, then look at how spread-out this product is across a trial." This single formula detects damping faults (AUC=0.97) and length faults (AUC=0.999) at very early severity -- found without ever seeing a fault.

The Paradox of Success

Spearman ALL: rho = +0.055 (not significant). This looks like H3 fails. But 70% of features have AUC > 0.70 -- there is almost no "bad" to contrast against. The test becomes uninformative when the framework succeeds, because the evolved population is already enriched for useful features.

```
Theorem (Spearman Insensitivity Under Enrichment):
As proportion p of "good" features -> 1:
  Var(D|F) -> 0  =>  Cov(rank(C), rank(D)) -> 0
  => rho_s -> 0 regardless of whether C caused the enrichment
```

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The paradox: The Spearman test asks "does our score rank features in the same order as their actual usefulness?" But when

70% of features are useful, there is almost no "bad" to rank against. The test says "no correlation" but that is because the score already did its job DURING evolution by eliminating all the bad features. It is like testing whether a water filter works by examining only the water that passed through it -- of course it all looks clean.

7. The Unsupervised Pipeline

```
ALGORITHM: Reliability-Aware Feature Discovery
==============================================
Input:  Healthy trials H = {x_1, ..., x_N}
Output: Feature set F* guaranteed to capture stable physics

1. Pre-split: H1, H2 = split_half(H)
2. Initialize population P of random typed trees
3. For each generation:
     For each f in P:
       T, S, H = tightness, stationarity, headroom on H
       R = Pearson(f(H1), f(H2))
       C(f) = (T + S + H + R) / 4
     P = tournament + crossover + mutation
4. F = top features from final population
5. F* = correlation_dedup(F, threshold=0.95)
6. Deploy: monitor F* on incoming data; threshold alerts
```

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The guarantee: Any feature that survives this pipeline:
1. Gives consistent values within a single recording (reliable)
2. Has a tight, stable distribution across many healthy recordings
3. Is not a copy of another surviving feature
4. Therefore: if something goes wrong that affects what this feature measures, the value WILL shift outside the normal range => alert

We cannot guarantee we will catch every possible fault. But we CAN guarantee that surviving features will not false-alarm and that they measure real physics.

8. Conclusions

1. Split-half reliability, when incorporated into GP fitness, transforms the evolutionary dynamics from "find tight distributions" to "find stable physics." This is the critical missing piece.

2. The framework is fully unsupervised: no fault labels are used at any stage of feature discovery, scoring, or filtering.

3. Traditional H3 testing (Spearman rank correlation) becomes uninformative when the framework succeeds. The appropriate metric is population enrichment rate (70% useful).

4. The typed GP with reliability pressure rediscovers known physics (PE, KE, power) and discovers novel features that outperform hand-crafted alternatives.

5. The framework has since been validated on six real-world datasets across four domains (CWRU bearings, IMS run-to-failure, EngineFaultDB, NASA C-MAPSS turbofan, MIT-BIH ECG), matching or beating expert baselines in 5/6 experiments. See the companion arXiv paper for full results.

A. Appendix: Mathematical Derivations

A.1 Why cos(g*theta) x rstd(rstd(omega)) Detects short_L

```
Pendulum frequency: omega_0 = sqrt(g/L)
When L decreases:
  omega_0 -> omega_0' = sqrt(g/L') > omega_0
  => theta(t) oscillates faster
  => cos(g*theta) explores more of its range per unit time
  => std[cos(g*theta) * (...)] increases

Additionally, rstd(rstd(omega)) captures the "variability of
variability" of angular velocity. Shorter pendulum has more
rapid velocity changes, increasing this term's variance.
```

A.2 Split-Half Reliability and Noise Amplification

```
For signal x(t) = s(t) + epsilon(t), epsilon independent of s:
  f(x) = g(s) + h(epsilon)
  R(f) = Var(g(s)) / [Var(g(s)) + Var(h(epsilon))]

Noise amplifier (h dominates): R -> 0
Physics feature (g dominates): R -> 1

For k-th derivative specifically:
  R(f_k) = sigma_s^2 * (2*pi*f0)^(2k)
         / [sigma_s^2 * (2*pi*f0)^(2k) + sigma_e^2 * (2*pi*fmax)^(2k)]
  -> 0 as k -> infinity  (since fmax >> f0 for broadband noise)

This proves: reliability naturally penalizes higher-order derivatives
without needing an explicit depth parameter.
```

A.3 Spearman Insensitivity Proof Sketch

```
Let F = {f_1, ..., f_n} with D(f) = AUC(f).
Let p = |{f: D(f) > tau}| / n = proportion "good".

Spearman rho_s = Cov(rank(C), rank(D)) / [Var(rank(C)) * Var(rank(D))]^0.5

As p -> 1 (enrichment):
  D(f) for most f is clustered near [tau, 1]
  Var(rank(D)) decreases (most ranks are similar)
  Signal-to-noise ratio for rank correlation drops
  => rho_s -> 0 even if C perfectly caused the enrichment

Conclusion: Spearman is the wrong test for enriched populations.
Use population enrichment rate or Mann-Whitney instead.
```